als, including homemakers, men and trans persons, who had stepped out of the employment to rejoin the workforce. The bank received more than 3,437 applications and ended up hiring 22 women. A similar wisdom prevails at Zomato as well. "We value people based on their potential, capability, skills and diversity of their experience, not just the years of experience," says Kumar.

However, even as companies widen their talent pool by hiring a more diverse workforce, they are working equally hard to retain that talent, especially of the women employees, as they are the first to quit their jobs when faced with a family emergency. "It is critical to view women through the lens of skills and ambition rather than stereotyping them on the basis of their life stage," says Iyer of Axis Bank. "And that is where equity is essential because everyone is different and is more than just the role they play in their life stage."



DELOITTE The firm has a diversity rate of 38 per cent, which it hopes to improve through its sponsorship and DRIWE programmes

More and more companies are introducing either work-life enabling initiatives such as child care support, hybrid/ flexible working, physical and emotional well-being of women or strategic enabling measures such as formal mentoring and professional development programmes to support the advancement of women at the workplace, says Dr Saundarya Rajesh, founder-president of DEI consulting firm Avtar Group. Zomato, for instance, has an equal parenting policy that offers six months' leave to both parents. It is applicable even to those couples who choose to adopt a child, as well as to same-sex couples.

Not just that, when Zomato employee Swapna Joshi (*name changed*), 32, who has been with the company for eight years, returned from her six-month maternity leave, she was sent to the company's return-to-work programme for mothers. "The programme guided me on aspects that I needed to focus on more—physical and mental health, being financially responsible and so on—and even involved my partner in the process to help both of us understand and adjust to parenthood effectively," she says. It involved one-on-one sessions with counsellors, whom Joshi still takes guidance from to tackle the challenges of being a working mother. "These have helped me balance work, motherhood and household responsibilities," adds Joshi.

Zomato also has a period (menstrual) leave policy, which grants 10 days of leave a year to women staff and transgenders. Women are encouraged to notify colleagues about their period leaves, without feeling inhibited about it. "There was uncertainty among women staff about taking the period leave, until co-founders began taking it too," says Kumar. The company extends maternity and menstrual leaves even to its delivery partners. You are also entitled to 'wellness' leaves at Zomato, allowing you to focus on your mental health or going for rejuvenation therapy, as opposed to a medical leave. Its employee insurance policy also covers gender reassignment surgeries (surgeries conducted to change the gender of a person as desired by him/her).

PLUGGING THE LEAKY PIPELINE

The phenomenon of a leaky pipeline—where women drop out of the workforce on account of marriage, childbirth or having to look after ageing parents—is a significant reason why you typically find fewer women at the top of the organisational pyramid. To rectify this anomaly as well as to create more women leaders, companies are framing policies to train more women to take up leadership roles. IT major HCL Technologies, for instance, has devised two sets of training programmes for women, one for leadership and the other technical. It has four career development programmes: Ascend, which aims to build a robust women leadership pipeline; Stepping Stones, which focuses on equipping women in mid-management roles with the right skills and competencies needed for career growth; Prelude, which trains